THINK TEST TREAT TB

Why should I get tested for Latent Tuberculosis (TB)?

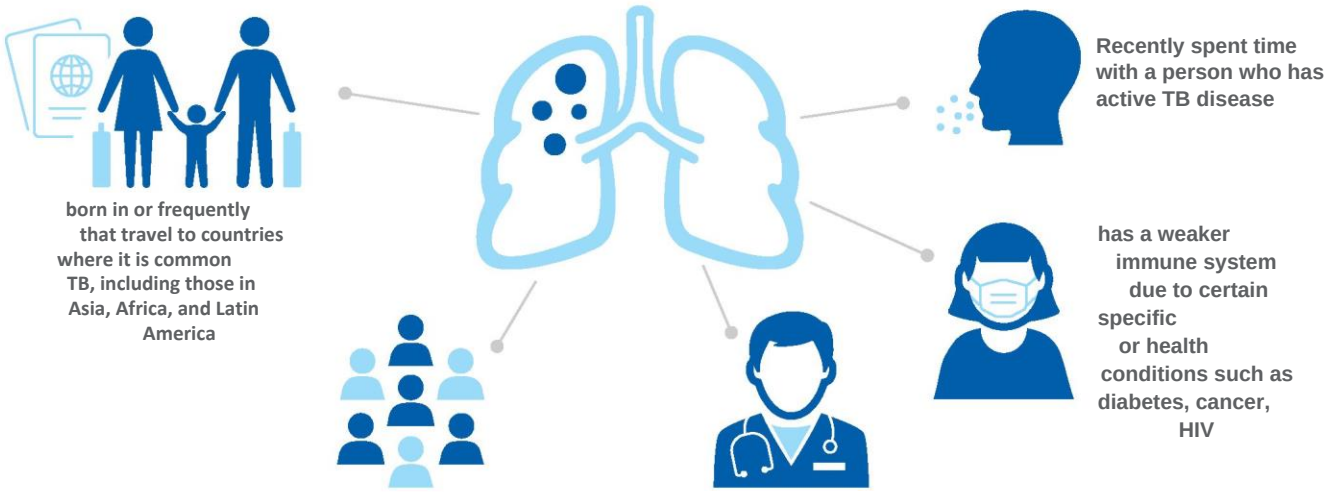
Tuberculosis, or TB disease, is highly contagious and can be deadly. The TB bacteria can live in your body for many years without causing symptoms. This is called latent TB or hidden TB infection. If untreated, latent TB can become active TB at any time and cause illness. When TB becomes active, it can spread to others through the air. By testing and treating latent TB, you can protect yourself, your family and friends, and your community.

1 Think

Is it possible for you to catch TB?

Millions of people in the United States have latent TB but are unaware of it.

Anyone can get TB, but the likelihood is higher that you will have TB if you are:



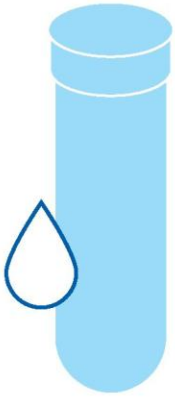
- born in or frequently that travel to countries where it is common TB, including those in Asia, Africa, and Latin America
- Recently spent time with a person who has active TB disease
- has a weaker immune system due to certain specific or health conditions such as diabetes, cancer, HIV
- live or have lived in large groups where more TB is common, such as the homeless shelters, jails, or prisons.
- work in places that have a higher risk of TB infection, such as those hospital, homeless shelters, facilities of jails, and homes of care

You may still be at risk of getting TB even if you have already received the TB vaccine (also called the BCG vaccine) because the protection weakens over time.

2 Get Tested

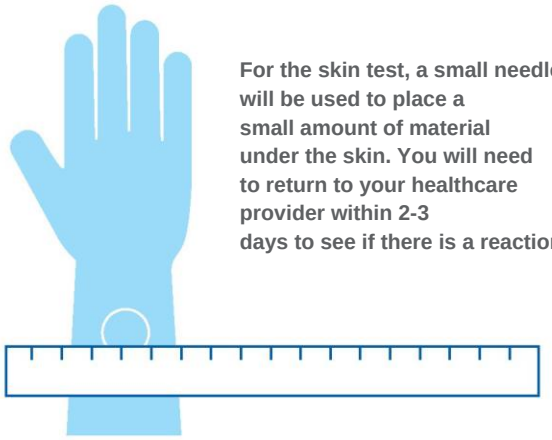
How are you tested for TB infection?

There are two types of tests for TB infection. Talk to your healthcare provider about which test is best for you.



Your healthcare provider may recommend a TB blood test because it can be done in a single visit, and it is more accurate if you have already been vaccinated for TB. The blood test measures how your immune system responds to the bacteria that cause TB.

TB Blood Test



For the skin test, a small needle will be used to place a small amount of material under the skin. You will need to return to your healthcare provider within 2-3 days to see if there is a reaction.

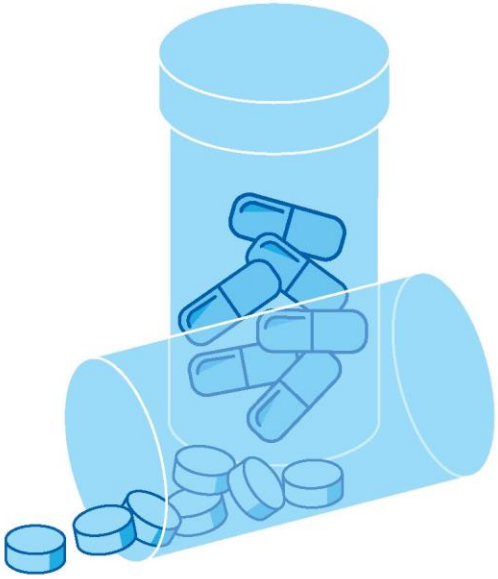
TB Skin Test

3 Get Treated

What are the treatment options? If

you have latent TB, there are short and convenient treatments available that can help protect you from the illness caused by active TB disease.

Treatment of latent TB infection is the best way to protect you from developing active TB disease. Talk with your healthcare provider about your medications and community resources available to support you in your treatment plan.



Public and private health plans may cover the costs of screening and treatment for TB infection.

To learn more about TB and how to protect yourself and others, visit www.cdc.gov/thinktesttreattb